



State of Ohio Administrative Policy

Ohio.gov Standardization & Registration of Domain Names

No: IT-06

Information Technology

Effective:

August 26, 2024

Issued By:

Kathleen C. Madden, Director

I. Purpose

This policy provides requirements for how Agencies standardize, obtain, and safeguard certain **Domain Names** by establishing naming requirements, and a central registration, tracking, and management process. The first occurrence of a defined term in the policy body outside of a title or heading is in bold, italic type, and is hyperlinked to the definition in Section IV.

II. Scope

This policy applies to all state Agencies, boards, and commissions under the authority of the Governor (collectively referred to as Agency or Agencies).

III. Policy

In the interest of establishing strong brand recognition, minimizing confusion for **Users**, simplifying statewide Domain Name management, and improving overall security, Agencies shall follow the registration, naming, and management requirements outlined in this policy.

A. **.gov Requirements:** Agencies shall register all State of Ohio-related **Internet** sites under a .gov domain.

1. When requesting a .gov Domain Name, the word “Ohio” shall be included within the **Second-Level Domain (SLD)**.
2. Agencies are encouraged to request **Third-Level Domain** “Ohio.gov” Domain Names (e.g., OAKS.Ohio.gov) rather than pursuing unique .gov SLDs. Registering a Third-Level “Ohio.gov” domain avoids a registration fee, ensures the domain will never expire, and clearly associates the domain with the “Ohio.gov” brand.

B. **.gov Naming Requirements:** Agencies shall ensure that they adhere to the following .gov naming requirements, which are in alignment with the DOTGOV Online Trust in Government Act of 2020 (6 U.S.C. § 665) and the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) DotGov Program Requirements:

1. The .gov domain shall not be used to advertise for private individuals, firms, or corporations, or imply in any manner that the government endorses or favors any specific commercial product, commodity, or service.
2. The .gov domain shall not be used for campaigning. The .gov websites may not be directly linked to or refer to websites created or operated by a campaign or any campaign entity or committee. No political sites, party names, acronyms or political causes shall be used.
3. Agencies shall avoid the use of “slang” within a Domain Name. For example, if a website is referring to a regulatory process, requesting “ohiofileupdates.gov” as a domain would be considered “slang,” or using terms such as “commish” instead of “commission.”
4. Agencies shall avoid the use of underscores within a Domain Name, and spaces are prohibited. Although not recommended, hyphens may be used, except at the beginning or end of a Domain Name.
5. Agencies shall avoid the use of names, acronyms, or abbreviations that are generic in nature or associated with, easily confused with, or too similar to those of another Agency, organization, or entity, or that could be interpreted as disparaging to a group or classification of Ohio residents.
6. A .gov domain must not be used to distribute or promote material when the distribution violates applicable law.
7. The .gov domain must not be used to distribute malware, host open redirects, or otherwise engage in malicious cyber activity.
8. The DHS CISA DotGov program and/or the Ohio Department of Administrative Services (DAS) Office of Information Technology (OIT) reserves the right to terminate any .gov domain that is not in compliance with the requirements set forth in this policy as well as the .gov domain requirements published by the DHS CISA.

C. **Use of Alternate Top-Level Domains (TLD):** If an Agency elects to use a **Top-Level Domain (TLD)** other than .gov, the Agency shall:

1. Submit all non-.gov domain registration requests to DAS OIT Unified Network Services (UNS) through the **DAS OIT Ordering System**.
2. Ensure that Users are redirected to an Ohio.gov domain.

- D. **Verify Domain Name Availability:** Agencies shall ensure that any desired Domain Name is available for acquisition. If it is determined that it is not feasible to obtain the desired Domain Name, the requesting Agency shall select another. The requesting Agency shall ensure the availability of a Domain Name before any marketing investments are made and/or any official notifications are distributed.
- E. **Purchase and Administration of Domain Names:** DAS shall purchase and administer domains on behalf of Agencies as well as any other state entities interested in using the DAS OIT service.
- F. **Domain Name Maintenance:** DAS OIT UNS shall maintain the internal and external **Domain Name Service** for the State of Ohio.
1. Only DAS OIT managed Domain Name servers shall be used to host and support all registered domains.
 2. The DAS OIT Office of Information Security and Privacy (OISP) shall review all new Domain Name requests and determine if a new **Domain-Based Message Authentication, Reporting and Conformance (DMARC)** record needs to be created to help ensure email security.
 - a) If a new DMARC record is required, DAS OIT OISP shall initiate and oversee its creation and implementation.
 - b) DAS OIT OISP shall annually audit DNS records to confirm a corresponding DMARC record exists.
 3. Domain Names shall be administered and renewed until a request for cancellation is received via the online DAS OIT Ordering System.
 - a) DAS OIT shall retain a Domain Name registration for a minimum of 12 months after a Web service is discontinued or migrated to another Domain Name.
 - b) During this 12-month period, a notice with the new Domain Name or a notice of service discontinuation shall be posted on the website of the Domain Name to be cancelled.
 4. DAS OIT UNS may delegate the administration of the **Domain Name System (DNS) Entries** to an Agency but must maintain oversight for those entries.
 - a) The DAS OIT UNS team shall audit any delegated DNS Entries at least once every 12 months to validate authenticity and consistency and to help mitigate the risk of domain hijacking.
 - b) The Agency that is granted delegated administration shall regularly perform audits and maintain documentation concerning the **DNS Zone(s)**. This documentation shall include, but not be limited to, a description of the service, current **Internet**

Protocol (IP) Address, and current target of the pointer at the folder or executable level.

5. DAS OIT UNS shall restrict DNS Zone transfers as a general practice.
 - a) The number of DNS servers that will be allowed to perform DNS Zone transfers shall be limited.
 - b) Individual Agency DNS servers shall not be authorized to perform DNS Zone transfers.
6. Agencies shall register all internal State of Ohio network assets and all necessary IP Addresses with DAS OIT UNS.
 - a) DAS OIT UNS and Agencies shall conduct periodic audits of network equipment and DNS information to ensure alignment with federal and state laws, polices, and regulations.
7. If DAS OIT UNS delegates authority to an Agency to manage any aspect of the DNS, **Dynamic Host Configuration Protocol (DHCP)**, or **IP Address Management (IPAM)** (the integration of DNS, DHCP, and IPAM into a unified service or solution is referred to as DDI), the authority shall be exercised through an account provisioned by DAS OIT UNS specifically for that purpose.
 - a) DAS OIT UNS shall create the account in alignment with the DAS password policy and standard requirements for **DAS-Managed System Assets** and assign the account to a specific Agency DDI Administrator. The account information shall not be shared with other Users.
 - b) If possible, the account shall only be accessed from within the State of Ohio network. If that is not feasible, the statewide virtual private network solution shall be used to access the account.
 - c) DAS OIT UNS shall audit DDI accounts for use.
 - (i) If an account is inactive for 90 days, the User shall be contacted to ensure they are still employed with the Agency. If the User is no longer with the Agency or no longer manages DDI, the account shall be immediately disabled. If the User is still with the Agency and still manages DDI, the User shall be given 30 days to login to the account. If the User does not access the account within the specified period, the account shall be disabled at the end of the 30 days.
 - (ii) To reinstate an account, Agencies must submit a request to DAS OIT UNS through DAS OIT's Ordering System.
 - d) Any violation of account protection or secure connection requirements shall result in a loss of DDI management privileges.

- G. **Policy Exceptions:** Any requests for exceptions to the Domain Name requirements outlined in this policy shall be submitted to DAS OIT for review and consideration (refer to section VII. Inquiries for the State IT Policy Manager contact information).
- H. **Procedures:** Agencies interested in registering or cancelling a Domain Name shall follow the procedures outlined below.
1. Agencies shall establish a primary and secondary administrative contact for managing Domain Names.
 - a) DAS OIT UNS shall be notified of changes in primary and/or secondary contacts as soon as practicable. In addition, DAS OIT UNS shall validate the list of Agency contacts on an annual basis.
 - b) The administrative contact shall request desired Domain Names by accessing DAS OIT's Ordering System and selecting "Telecommunication Services/Domain Services." A justification for the domain and IP Address shall be included in the DAS OIT's Ordering System request.
 - c) The administrative contact shall be responsible for providing all required information on the Domain Services order form.
 - d) In addition, the Agency administrative contact shall provide any relevant procedure or domain inventory updates to DAS OIT UNS as soon as possible.
 2. The requested Domain Name(s) shall be reviewed by DAS OIT UNS and, if approved, acquired by DAS through an approved registrar for the requested TLD.
 3. Upon successfully registering a requested Domain Name, notification will be sent to the Agency administrative contact.
 4. To cancel a Domain Name, the Agency administrative contact shall access the DAS OIT's Ordering System and select "remove domain" from the menu on the Domain Services order form.
 5. DAS OIT UNS shall invoice Agencies via a voucher of intrastate payment for all costs associated with registration and administration of Domain Names.

IV. Definitions

- A. **DAS-Managed System Assets.** Information, hardware, software, and services required to support state business, and identified during the risk assessment process as assets that need to be protected. Primary responsibility for managing these system assets may be assigned to DAS OIT personnel or outside entities.
- B. **Domain Name.** A Domain Name is used to locate computers on the Internet and to allow users to reach websites. Each Domain Name has at least two components, the Top-Level Domain

Name and the secondary level Domain Name. Structurally, TLDs and SLDs are combined to create a Domain Name address: www.secondlevel.toplevel.

- C. Domain-Based Message Authentication, Reporting and Conformance (DMARC). An email authentication method that improves security by helping mitigate common cyber threats, including email **Spoofing** and **Phishing**.
- D. DAS OIT's Ordering System. DAS OIT's Ordering System allows users to order statewide services online, including telecommunication services such as domain services, Wireless as a Service, mobile services, and Internet access. These requests are submitted online in ServiceNow.
- E. Domain Name Service. The Ohio Department of Administrative Services Office of Information Technology Unified Network Services provides a domain name service to Agencies as well as any other interested state entities. The service offering includes installing, administering, and maintaining internal and external Domain Name System servers for customers.
- F. Domain Name System (DNS). The system by which Internet domain names and addresses are tracked and regulated.¹
- G. Domain Name System (DNS) Entries. A DNS Entry is any number of records that can be added to a DNS Zone or subzone/child zone. These entries can be in the form of a mapping of the zone to the corresponding Internet Protocol Addresses (A Record), a mapping to a name server (NS Record), or a text entry for domain validation (TXT Record).
- H. Domain Name System (DNS) Zone. A logical organizational structure for the DNS that allows for the management of granular components by an administrator.
- I. Dynamic Host Configuration Protocol (DHCP). The automatic assignment of Internet Protocol addresses to network connected devices.
- J. Internet. A worldwide system of computer networks - a network of networks - in which computer users can get information and access services from other computers. The Internet is generally considered to be public, untrusted, and outside the boundary of the State of Ohio network.
- K. Internet Protocol (IP) Address. A unique number that is a four (IPv4) or eight (IPv6) octet source or destination number, which identifies a computing device on a network.
- L. Internet Protocol (IP) Address Management (IPAM). The practice of planning and managing the IP address space on a network.

¹ Akram, Mehwish, William C. Barker, Rob Clatterbuck, Donna Dodson, Brandon Everhart, Jane Gilbert, William Haag, Brian Johnson. "NIST Special Publication 1800-16, Securing Web Transactions TLS Server Certificate Management," U.S. Department of Commerce National Institute of Standards and Technology and National Cybersecurity Center of Excellence, June 2020 < <https://nvlpubs.nist.gov/nistpubs/SpecialPublications/NIST.SP.1800-16.pdf>>.

- M. Phishing. A technique for attempting to acquire sensitive data, such as bank account numbers, through a fraudulent solicitation in email or on a website, in which the perpetrator masquerades as a legitimate business or reputable person.²
- N. Second-Level Domain (SLD). The Second-Level Domain is the next highest level of the hierarchy after the Top-Level Domain. SLDs are typically selected to relate to specific information or services offered or to identify the organization providing the information. Structurally, TLDs and SLDs are combined to create a Domain Name address: www.secondlevel.toplevel.
- O. Spoofing. Faking the sending address of a transmission to gain illegal entry into a secure system.³
- P. Third-Level Domain. The Third-Level Domain is an additional layer or subdomain, which can provide further Domain Name clarification. An example of a Third-Level Domain is OAKS in this Domain Name: address: www.OAKS.ohio.gov.
- Q. Top-Level Domain (TLD). The Top-Level Domain is the basic component of a Domain Name address (e.g., .gov).
- R. User. For the purposes of this policy, Users are defined as employees, contractors, temporary personnel, and other agents of the state who administer or use privately-owned (if authorized) or state-owned IT resources on behalf of the state.

V. Authority

ORC 125.02, 125.04, 125.18

VI. Resources

Document Name	Location
DOTGOV Online Trust in Government Act of 2020 (6 U.S.C. § 665)	https://uscode.house.gov/view.xhtml?req=(title:6%20section:665%20edition:prelim)%20OR%20(granuleid:USC-prelim-title6-section665)&f=treesort&edition=prelim&num=0&jumpTo=true

² Nieves, Michael, Kelley Dempsey, and Victoria Yan Pillitteri. "NIST Special Publication 800-12 Revision 1, An Introduction to Information Security," U.S. Department of Commerce National Institute of Standards and Technology, June 2017 <<https://nvlpubs.nist.gov/nistpubs/SpecialPublications/NIST.SP.800-12r1.pdf>>.

³ Bartock, Michael, Joseph Brule, Ya-Shian Li-Baboud, Suzanne Lightman, James McCarthy, Karri Meldorf, Karen Reczek, Doug Northrip, Arthur Scholz, Theresa Suloway. "NIST Internal Report NIST IR 8323r1 Foundational PNT Profile: Applying the Cybersecurity Framework for the Responsible Use of Positioning, Navigation, and Timing (PNT) Services," U.S. Department of Commerce National Institute of Standards and Technology, January 2023, <<https://nvlpubs.nist.gov/nistpubs/ir/2023/NIST.IR.8323r1.pdf>>.

Document Name	Location
Department of Homeland Security Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) DotGov Program	https://get.gov/
CISA Domain Requirements	https://home.dotgov.gov/registration/requirements/
Internet Corporation for Assigned Names and Numbers (ICANN) Website	https://www.icann.org/
Internet Assigned Numbers Authority (IANA) Listing of Generic (gTLD) and Country Code (ccTLD) Top Level Domains (TLDs)	http://www.iana.org/domains/root/db/
IANA WHOIS Service	https://www.iana.org/whois
Internet Engineering Task Force Data Tracker	https://datatracker.ietf.org/
Ohio Administrative Policy IT-08 Website Standardization	https://das.ohio.gov/technology-and-strategy/policies/it-08

VII. Inquiries

Direct inquiries about Domain Name registration and maintenance to:

Customer Service Center
Office of Information Technology
Ohio Department of Administrative Services
1320 Arthur E. Adams Drive, Room 310
Columbus, Ohio 43221-3595

614-644-6860 | 877-644-6860 | csc@ohio.gov

Direct inquiries about this policy to:

State IT Policy Manager
Investment and Governance Division
Office of Information Technology
Ohio Department of Administrative Services
30 East Broad Street, 39th Floor
Columbus, Ohio 43215

614-644-6860 | DAS.State.ITPolicy.Manager@das.ohio.gov

State of Ohio Administrative Policies may be found online at
<https://das.ohio.gov/technology-and-strategy/policies>

VIII. Revision History

Date	Description of Change
08/26/2005	Original Policy.
12/21/2012	Revised the policy requirements to further establish the Ohio.gov brand throughout the state and updated the Domain Name registration procedures to reflect current practices. Also, transferred the policy content into a new State of Ohio Administrative Policy Template. Re-numbered policy to IT-06 to be consistent with new numbering format.
01/29/2018	The link for DAS OIT's Ordering System was updated to reflect a change in the system used as well as ordering terminology. Due to the clerical nature of the update, the effective date was not changed.
07/22/2021	Updated the policy template to reflect the DAS director change.
08/26/2024	Removed references to the General Services Administration and updated the requirements to align with those of the DOTGOV Act of 2020 and DHS CISA. Updated the .gov naming requirements based on current standards. Agencies are required to submit all non-.gov domain registration requests to DAS OIT Unified Network Services. A Domain Name Maintenance Section that includes new registration, management, auditing, security, and documentation requirements. Modifications to the Procedures Section to clarify the requirements. Updated the Resources Section based on the federal .gov domain administering authority transition. The definitions were updated to align with the current terminology. The policy template was modified to align with the current format.
08/26/2026	Scheduled policy review.